Escalation still likely despite midterms rout

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【メール原文】

The US is still likely to escalate against Iran, as Trump looks to break the deadlock before Democrats take control of Congress in 2027.||||||||||||||||

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What Happened

Oil prices fell sharply to $95 per barrel for Brent on Wednesday based on the expectation that the US was less likely to escalate against Iran following extensive Republican defeats in the midterm elections.

Our Take

Escalation remains likely (60%, down from 65%). Despite heavy losses in the midterm elections, President Donald Trump retains the option to launch new kinetic strikes against Iran. He's likely to use that option, in an attempt to break the deadlock with Iran at the negotiating table (see: The US will likely strike Iran in mid-November , 27 October 2026). Despite the recent drop in oil prices, escalation is likely to produce a sharper increase, into a band of $110-$125 per barrel for Brent.

Trump is unlikely to be swayed by the threat of near-term criticism of the war from Democrats, though he faces internal GOP fractures that weaken his control of the party and could lead him to hesitate over a decision to launch new strikes. We still expect escalation, however, as Trump's latitude to act will narrow substantially after the new year when Democrats can leverage government funding to limit his options. He has a narrowing window to break the stalemate with Iran through military force, and attempting to do so remains more attractive than cutting a bad deal or enduring the continued standoff.

A deal is possible but appears increasingly unlikely (10%, down from 20%). Iran's demands are steep: a return to the June MOU, an end to the blockade of Iran as well as the release of frozen funds and sanctions relief for Iranian oil exports, in exchange for reopening the Strait of Hormuz. Iran also expects its control over Hormuz to be recognized. Iran has shown little flexibility in recent mediated talks and the midterm outcome has likely emboldened its leaders—they are unlikely to shift in their position. While eager to end the war, Trump will resist taking a deal that will be broadly interpreted as a defeat.

Uncertainty over escalatory options could delay strikes or produce a smaller-scale action. The White House has been considering new strikes on Iran for weeks and has multiple options; as yet, there are few strong signs Trump has settled on a strategy.

A large-scale bombing campaign would increase internal pressure on Iran but would trigger much more violent Iranian retaliation. A more focused campaign, directed against Iran's military and its assets in

the Persian Gulf, could degrade Iran's capabilities and aid US efforts at moving energy out of the Strait of Hormuz. There is also the possibility that Trump opts for something more symbolic, striking a few high-profile targets such as Iran's nuclear facility at Pickaxe Mt., in order to produce a narrative of victory that could then justify a pivot to accepting a deal.

Odds of a continued standoff have increased (30%, up from 15%). Unable to decide on an escalation strategy and unwilling to reach a deal with the Iranians on their terms, Trump may opt to stay the course and maintain pressure on Iran—a course many of his advisors reportedly support, though one that will not bring any near-term resolution to the conflict.

Gregory Brew
Senior Analyst, Iran & Energy
+1 646 259 3207
brew@eurasiagroup.net
Clayton Allen
Practice Head, United States
+1 202.903.0027
allen@eurasiagroup.net
Firas Maksad
Managing Director, Middle East & North Africa
+1 202.552.5384
maksad@eurasiagroup.net
Marc Gustafson
Managing Director, Analysis
+1 202.540.5144
gustafson@eurasiagroup.net
EG Middle East & North Africa
mena@eurasiagroup.net
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